Indigenous Data Commons

Information sheet: the Indigenous Data Commons

A public-facing introduction to the datasets, research, maps, archives, agreements and practical resources described through the Indigenous Data Commons.

A growing, connected metadata collection

The Indigenous Data Commons helps people discover information by, for and about Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples: what it is, where it is held, and whether and how it can be accessed. It brings together content descriptions from participating collections and organisations, making many kinds of material easier to find while allowing those responsible for the material to retain control over it.

The Commons is growing. Its contents reflect the work and priorities of participating communities, researchers, archives and organisations. Its coverage continues to expand as more communities and organisations contribute descriptions of their resources.

What you can find

The Commons describes many kinds of resources, not only datasets.

Datasets and research collections

Research data on population, health, education, the environment and other subjects, together with information about how the data were created and who is responsible for them.

Publications and research

Journal articles, theses, working papers, reports and other research outputs, including substantial collections of Indigenous research from Australian universities.

Maps and spatial information

Maps, boundaries and other place-based information that help people explore connections between data and Country, culture, communities, services and events.

Archives and significant collections

Descriptions of historically and culturally significant collections, including papers, photographs, correspondence, population and genealogical records, as well as research archives. Some projects also preserve information about collections at risk of being lost.

Agreements, treaties and settlements

Records of agreements, treaties and negotiated settlements between Indigenous peoples, governments and other parties. These include agreements relating to land, native title, housing, health, services and economic development, along with information about the people and organisations involved.

Common terminology and data rights guidance

Shared lists of names and terms used to describe places, languages, organisations, industries, data rights and other subjects consistently. These resources make information easier to find across different collections and include notices and labels that can communicate community expectations about access and use.

What you can do

Using the metadata entry tool, you can make a metadata record about your collection and share it. If you have a dataset that is at risk, with approval, you can transfer it to the Keeping Place while maintaining ownership and controlling access.

Themes across the Commons

The material covers a wide and expanding range of themes.

Country and environment
Land, waters, environments and biodiversity

Culture and community
Culture, language, heritage and community life

Health and population
Health, wellbeing, population and demography

Everyday life and services
Education, employment, housing and community services

Law and public life
Law, policy, government and public administration

Land rights and development
Native title, land use, agreements and economic development

People and organisations
Indigenous organisations, researchers and community-controlled services

Data rights and governance
Indigenous data governance, rights, access and responsible use

Descriptions, links and access

The Commons is a catalogue that connects records from many different organisations.

A record in the Commons might describe an item held by a university, community organisation, archive, government agency or another custodian. The record then provides a link to the place where it is managed.

Finding a record does not necessarily mean that the material itself is open to everyone. Some items can be viewed or downloaded online; others require permission, contact with the owner or custodian, or observance of cultural protocols. Each participating organisation or contributor remains responsible for its collections and access decisions.

Resources, including datasets, are described using widely adopted data standards so that information from different organisations can work together. Just as importantly, descriptions can carry information about custodianship, rights, cultural authority and conditions of use.

Explore the catalogue data.idnau.org/search